



AI in StarCraft

After beating the best Go player in the world, AI's next goal is to master StarCraft.
<http://dgit.in/AICraft>



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Feature

THE RIGHT TO CONNECT

Are we being denied a basic right in the name of law and order?



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The conversation around digital rights has gained a lot of momentum in recent times. It was only last year that the entire furore over net neutrality in India took place. And over this one year alone, we have seen issues around censorship and freedom of expression in our online lives in India. Even if we might have advanced on some of these, a pretty interesting statistic has brought to our attention another online issue in our country – the access to internet itself.

According to a survey by Brookings Institution, India had more internet blockages between July 2015 and June 2016, than any other country in the world – at par with Iraq at 22 blockages. That's more than Syria (non-ISIS), Pakistan, Turkey, Bangladesh and Brazil – the next five countries in the

list – combined. Some of these countries are under the lashes of long wars on terror and some have strict autocratic regimes that aren't exactly big on freedom of expression. And talking about lashes, we're actually higher than Saudi Arabia on the list.

Now, it wouldn't be fair to portray this as an equal comparison. We do enjoy more freedom of expression online than, say, a Saudi Arabian citizen can. But to be honest, should that even be a justification for being denied access to the internet? On the other hand, the internet is also a source of a large amount of misinformation – some of which can be pretty dangerous for the uninformed. So what exactly does the internet mean to you – a law abiding citizen of the largest democracy in the world?

HOW BAD IS IT?

India has had 31 internet blockages in 2016, according to research by the Software Freedom Law Centre (SFLC).

That's one for every 12 days. Now, don't for a second assume that these blockages are nationwide – nothing even close to that has been done. However, these are region-based blanket blockages which essentially disable internet access from the network end. You can check out a very useful tracker at <http://dgit.in/NetShtdwn>. A place like Kashmir had its internet access blocked for months. In 2017, the count has already reached 10 and we just entered the second quarter.

What makes it worse are the kind of reasons for which the access has been blocked on some occasions. For instance, mobile internet services were suspended for four hours across Gujarat on 28th February, 2016 to prevent cheating on the Revenue Accountants Recruitment Exam. To be honest, most of the cases that account for such high numbers happened due to situations of unrest in said states – mostly due to communal clashes. But there are situations where the normalisation of